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Words and the Dogon world

Author(S): Calame-Griaule, Geneviève, LaPin, Deirdre

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Riddles in the Courtship of Women

Although frequent joking between couples would give the impression that their relationships are always harmonious, in reality there remains a latent tension. Dogon men live in constant fear that their wives will leave them, and Dogon women are aware that on leaving they will be left entirely to their own resources. But they are also aware that it will be easier for them to find another husband than for their husbands to find another wife. The scorn that Dogon men show toward women, along with their outspoken feelings of superiority, are actually part of a constant fear of being abandoned.¹²² Dogon husbands, while proclaiming their general disdain for women, will do everything they can to keep their own wives. Thus the perpetually endangered balance is restored.

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There are many reasons behind the practice of polygamy among the Dogon; some are the arduous working conditions in the cliffs, the high rate of child mortality, and the strong desire to be assured of having offspring. But because of this custom there is a scarcity of wives. Given the custom of yà:bíru one would think that every man would be provided a wife from childhood onward through his parent's efforts. But the fact is that very few Dogon women spend their whole lives with the husband given them in early marriage. There are some examples of "serious" women (dím[unknown] y[unknown]s[unknown])¹²³ who bring gladness to the houses of their husband and their father; also to their children, as it is "shameful to have several fathers."¹²⁴ But for the most part, these serious women are harder to find than the less substantial type.

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Early marriage is often interrupted by divorce before the young woman has been received into her husband's family. During this preliminary period, young people often conclude that they are not suited to one another, and the young woman will prefer to  376 claim her freedom before observing the marriage rituals, which are essentially culinary, that would bind her to her husband's gínna. Dogon women, at least when young, are constantly changing partners through marriage, divorce and remarriage, and their instability is a constant source of worry for the men. Their obsession with their wife's departure is a constant topic of conversation. This is why Dogon husbands work at being "patient" during quarrels and spats; anything to them is better than being left by their wives. Divorce is rarely his doing, but in such a case it is considered to be irreparable; whereas, if it is caused by the wife or by one of the two families, relatives and friends will try to smooth out the difficulty.¹²⁵

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122. According to Dr. Parin this obsession is most often encountered in boys who are weaned late and suddenly, as is the case among the Dogon.

123. Dím[unknown] is a complex term which simultaneously expresses the idea of kindness, patience, and strong character traits and also the notion of inexhaustible abundance. Parin, Morgenthaler, et al. observe that Diamagundo's present wife is a yà: bíru, whereas two yàk[unknown]du have left him (1963:340).

124. After a boy's mother remarries and goes to live elsewhere, he will refuse to go see her, claiming that his father's new wife is his mother. A daughter does not have the same scruples and remains tied to her mother.

125. "When it is the man who divorces, there is no remedy" (ána gò: jó[unavailable]u s[unknown]l[unknown]). "Divorced wife" is said "Wife who has gone out" (yà: gò:). The term for divorce is "waste of a marriage" (yà:ji: yàmala for a man or íg[unknown] [unknown] yàmala for a woman). Reconciliation is "set the marriage in order" (yà:ji: y[unknown]g[unknown]r[unknown]).

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



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